

# The Observer

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## SPRAWLING TOWARD SOLIPSISM

**THE SUBURB IS AN  
OBSOLETE AND  
CONTRADICTIONARY  
FORM OF HUMAN  
SETTLEMENT.**

— *A Pattern Language*

Despite Washington State's decade-old Growth Management Act, suburban sprawl continues to gobble up valuable farm land, destroy fish and wildlife habitat, and further erode our patterns of social and political behavior. Hamstrung by defective economic thinking, irresponsible developers, and egocentric elected officials, suburban dwellers face a dim future dominated by noisy, smelly automobiles, gobs of traffic congestion, and a life of vapid homogeneity. Worse, we have become a nation of boring solipsists.



# Excursions

## TAKE BACK THE STREETS

Before writing this piece I took some time to review previous *Observer* issues, which began in February 1994 with an extensive interview with former County Councilor Peter Hurley.

**Observer:** What is the county going to look like in five years, in 10 years?

**Hurley:** Oh, in the next 10 years trends will continue the degradation. Crime will be up. Habitat loss will be up. And yet, that doesn't mean that you don't keep working to make it better...Maybe the right thing is raising your children and other cultures to respect diversity and be tolerant and to protect all other living creatures. And maybe the right thing to do is to go out and be active in poli-

tics, write letters to the editor.

Like a lot of politicians, Hurley ran for office, in part, because of a negative encounter with local government. He had been fighting to protect sensitive areas from further development. Yet he admitted to *The Observer* that matters had gotten worse during his four years on the county council: developers, with local governments' approval, continued to pollute streams, destroy wetlands, and subsidize the automobile industry.

Hurley had also expressed regret over not having done "a very good job of articulating a more positive vision, a more positive way to live." I believe that he was saying the right things; the rest of us just weren't paying attention.

You may recall that Hurley had been instrumental in bringing to Everett Andres Duany, one of the founders of New Urbanism, a growing movement within the architectural and design community. The New Urbanists seek "a more positive way to live" by designing pedestrian-friendly, environmentally responsible communities that rely on the traditional elements of neighborhood.

Hurley realized that railing against developers was not enough to win the hearts and minds of citizens. It was incumbent on those who desired to preserve open spaces and forested lands to build *up* not out, and to do so in a way that captures the sense of community that

## RESIST THE STATUS QUO

The value of philosophy is, in fact, to be sought largely in its very uncertainty. The man who has no tincture of philosophy goes through life imprisoned in the prejudices derived from common sense, from the habitual beliefs of his age or his nation, and from convictions which have grown up in his mind without the cooperation or consent of his deliberate reasons. To such a man the world tends to become definite, finite, obvious; common objects rouse no questions, and unfamiliar possibilities are contemptuously rejected.

— Bertrand Russell

suburbia cannot provide.

But look around us. We have no examples of traditional neighborhoods, where residents can walk to work, stores, schools, restaurants, movie theaters, and city hall. Instead, we have allowed developers and governments to fragment our lives and keep us apart. Above all, we have become so dependent on the automobile that we cannot imagine what it would be like to use our feet, ride a trolley, or pedal our bicycles. Besides, even if we wanted to visit them, we have no museums in the suburbs, no art galleries, and very few parks.

A decade ago Peter Hurley felt a strong sense of urgency in arresting sprawl. He was driven by his abiding appreciation for the natural environment and his desire to protect it from further encroachment. Ten years later, I dare suggest that even more is at stake: our political democracy and civil society.

In the recent issue of *Dissent*, philosopher Michael Walzer tells us "that only a revival of associative life will produce a political revival, and only a political revival will produce the commitment (and eventually the resources) necessary to overcome the inequality of [the associative life]." Political participation among Americans has diminished to the point that most of us don't bother to vote, let alone engage in political discourse at the local pub or coffee house. Union membership is but a third of its highest level, which was achieved in 1945. Membership in associations is also down. But the clubs that the few of us join are fragmented along racial, religious, and economic lines. That is, as Walzer suggests, our associative life, however diminished, tends to reinforce inequality.

Harvard political scientist Robert Putnam, in his study of Italian states, found a strong

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correlation between membership in associations and political participation. In turn, a citizenry's high political participation (e.g., voting rates and party politics) correlated with a strong civil society, the very relationship Walzer stresses above.

But there's much more at stake, according to Richard G. Wilkinson, the Senior Research Fellow at The Trafford Centre for Medical Research of the University of Sussex. He argues that our very inequalities in wealth and social standing contribute to "unhealthy societies."

Wilkinson cites the small town of Roseta, Pennsylvania. First populated in the 1880s by immigrants from an Italian city of the same name, Roseta attracted researchers because of its low death rates from heart disease, which were 40 percent below the norm. Why? The residents smoked tobacco, drank alcohol, ate the kind of food, and exercised at the same levels as the typical American. What was indeed different about Roseta, the researchers concluded, was its tight-knit community.

From the beginning the sense of common purpose and camaraderie among the Italians precluded ostentation or embarrassment to the less affluent, and the concern for neighbors ensured that no one was ever abandoned. This pattern of remarkable social cohesion, in which the family, as the hub and bulwark of life, provided a kind of security and insurance against any catastrophe, was associated with the striking absence of myocardial infarction and sudden death. [as quoted in *Unhealthy Societies*, by Richard G. Wilkinson]

Things began to change for Roseta in the 1960s. The strong sense of egalitarianism that had marked the townspeople for generations gradually eroded in the face of increasing commercialism, no doubt made possible by the growing influence of television. Like the rest of America, Rosetans could not ignore the allure of "status symbols—expensive clothes, large automobiles, and elaborate new homes furnished on the advice of interior decorators." The town of Roseta, so stable and healthy in its egalitarian ways, fragmented along economic lines and social standing. Today, Rosetans suffer heart attacks with the same frequency as other Americans.

**I**n the next few issues of *The Observer* I will be focusing on the need for an urban renaissance to both preserve the existing natural environment and, more important, to facilitate the restoration of what Gunnar Myrdal called 'the American Creed.'

Let me put it bluntly. In our collective stupidity we have allowed, if not encouraged, tens of thousands of US citizens to die in terrible wars fought on strange soils to defend a democracy that most of us fail to practice. When we are not fighting wars we are spending money as if we were, keeping a bloated Pentagon awash in more money than even its own officials say they need.

We have forgotten "the principle of civic participation," to use Tocqueville's words. We are cursedly ignorant of history and most of us cannot name the current crop of people who presume to represent us.

But why should we care at all? What difference does anything make? Most of us don't bother to subscribe to a newspaper; we're more likely to own a gun

than read the *Seattle Times* every day. And those who read for knowledge rarely associate with those who fire pistols.

A few years ago, in my last issue of *The Observer*, I wrote an essay entitled "The Culture of Separation." I spoke of the Republican Contract with America, the anomie of suburban life, and the continuing isolation of the white middle class from everyone else. I included a 1988 quotation from then-Congressman Newt Gingrich: "Now we have a way of dividing America" through so-called 'wedge issues' like crime, family, education, and—the worst epithet of all—"liberals."

Today, over a decade later, our country is even more divided, as our federal representatives evenly split the vote on whether

or not to toss out of office a twice-elected president. Last November Washingtonians joined California in banning affirmative action programs; in marking our ballots we had the audacity to invoke the very words of the martyred Dr. King. Meanwhile, the average price for a home in Snohomish County threatens to reach a quarter-million dollars as record numbers are turned away from homeless shelters.

Lincoln warned that a house divided against itself cannot stand. With the greatest income disparity of any western nation, with more black men in jail than in college, and with nearly everything for sale, America wobbles perilously, its public foundation eroded from generations of civic neglect.

## CHOMSKY ON COMMUNITIES

"...to be effective, democracy requires that people feel a connection to their fellow citizens...A vibrant political culture needs community groups, libraries, public schools, neighborhood organizations, cooperatives, public meeting places, voluntary associations, and trade unions to provide ways for citizens to meet, communicate, and interact with their fellow citizens. Neoliberal democracy [the prevailing ideology of the U.S.], with its notion of the market *über alles*, takes dead aim at this sector. Instead of citizens, it produces consumers. Instead of communities, it produces shopping malls. The net result is an atomized society of disengaged individuals who feel demoralized and socially powerless."

—Noam Chomsky,  
*Profit Over People: neoliberalism and global order*

# UGLY DYSFUNCTIONAL BURG

We have sprawled in earnest following WWII, fueled by cheap gasoline, a government-subsidized highway system, and the ubiquitous automobile. As a result, our patterns of living look much different than they did before the advent of the “asphalt nation.”

Before the war, people who didn’t work on farms nestled in lively urban centers. Main Street featured multi-storied buildings abutting wide sidewalks with stores or offices on the ground floor and apartments stacked above. People walked to work or hopped aboard electric trolleys. A brief stroll around the corner could fetch a fresh loaf of bread. Families lived in real neighborhoods and Sunday meals served as social gatherings. Most city dwellers read daily newspapers, perhaps several, and evenings were spent talking politics at the local pub or sitting around the Philco. A minute’s drive beyond the city limits revealed dozens of small family farms and vast unspoiled landscapes.

Today we don’t walk, because our houses and apartments are located too far from stores, parks, and places of employment. Our present-day communities exhibit utter contempt for the rare pedestrian who ventures outside to confront the tons of steel and rubber plying our suburban streets.

When buildings fail to define public space at a scale congenial to humans—as along any commercial highway strip—people cannot be there in safety and comfort. They will not walk there. They will not pause to



*Welcome to Marysville, Washington*

minge there with other people. They will not communicate there (or put anything in common). They will not contribute to a social organism that is larger than themselves...Such places are therefore profoundly uncivil. They impoverish and diminish us socially, and the community pays an enormous price for this incivility in terms of social dysfunction, ruined institutions, and misbehavior. Civilization becomes impossible under these conditions.<sup>1</sup>

A quick glance at an aerial photograph of the typical American suburban city shows a library in one corner, a K-Mart in another, city hall a couple of blocks off Broadway, the police station down the road, pockets of apartment buildings, scattered schools, strip malls rimming both sides of congested roadways, and acre after acre of single-family homes filling up the landscape. The parks are few and far between, the streams usually polluted by the runoff from over-fertilized lawns, and indigenous species have long since vanished.

In short, we have become masters of fragmentation and

despoliation. We keep retail shops separate from office buildings. Libraries, museums (if there are any), city halls, public art galleries—those things that populate the civic realm—we distribute across suburbia, keeping them separate from each other. We create intricate zoning regulations that guarantee the poor will never sleep in the same neighborhood as the rich.

Developers tell us that they hastily erect ugly, poorly constructed look-alike houses because that’s what people want. The American Dream, after all, is to own that garage-dominated modern-day log cabin packed side by side with the other log



cabins in places called 'Rolling Green Estates' or 'Hawthorn Hill.' A couple of sport utility vehicles parked in the driveway would complete the picture.

In October 1990 the Puget Sound Council of Governments published a report entitled "Vision 2020: Growth and Transportation Strategy for the Central Puget Sound Region." The report, citing prosperity-induced population increases, called "for the containment of growth, limiting the extent of sprawl into surrounding farmlands, forests and open spaces." But the effects of growth, the report continued, "cannot be blamed on economic prosperity alone. Many of these problems have their origins in the lifestyles that residents have *chosen* in response to prosperity: single-family homes on spacious lots, the private auto as the preferred method of travel, decentralized work places surrounded by free parking, and traditional preferences for local government control [emphasis added]."

The American dream has run smack into "the tragedy of the commons." Our apparent desire to live in "single-family homes on spacious lots" cannot be realized by everyone: there is simply not enough cheap land to accommodate continued sprawl.

But prosperity and individual choice are not the only reasons

we've run out of room. Governments have subsidized the development industry.

Indeed, all too often people in the development industry manipulate local governments to achieve their ends. As with almost any subsidy, the resulting product—in our case, hastily erected, ugly, poorly constructed look-alike houses—occurs with greater frequency than that determined by the law of supply and demand.

**Sprawl creates a vicious circle. In order to arrest its spread, the people must achieve a critical mass of political power. But the very patterns of sprawl—segregated uses, lack of public space, and a broadly dispersed population—thwart participatory democracy.**

Developer subsidies in the form of reduced or non-existent impact fees encourage sprawl, which yields the mono-cultural and democratically stifled suburbia some of us have widely condemned but cannot seem to do much about.

And we should not be surprised. Sprawl creates a vicious circle. In order to arrest its spread, the people must achieve a critical mass of political power. Yet the very patterns of sprawl—segregated uses, lack of public space, and a broadly dispersed population—thwart participatory democracy.

We can begin by acknowledging the obvious: we can no longer abide the status quo.

What is wrong with sprawl? Four things: it is expensive, dangerous, anti-environmental, and anti-social.<sup>2</sup>

In his book *The Car and the City* author Alan Durning estimates that the typical automobile costs the average family \$300 a month. Building twelve residential units per acre costs \$23,000 per house for infra-

structure, defined as roads, sewer, electric lines, water pipes, television cables, phone lines, and storm drainage systems. Trash collection and fire protection are more expensive in sprawling suburbs than in denser cities. Suburbanites spend an average of 32 hours a month commuting and another 27 hours at work to pay for the car.

The suburbs dangerous?

In their haste to escape alleged crime-ridden cities, people actually increase their chances of injury and death by moving to the suburbs. The white middle class homeowner in Marysville or Arlington is more likely to be killed in an automobile accident than an urban resident risks being fatally shot on the streets of Seattle. As Durning concludes, "All told, city dwellers are much safer."

Sprawl gobbles up forests, agricultural lands, and natural habitats. Between 1970 and 1990, the gobbling occurred at twice the rate of population growth. Ten years ago, Seattle gobbled up "nine square miles of woodland, farmland, and other open space each year," writes Durning.

In the end, sprawl destroys democracy and creates more



Republicans. "The landscape of sprawl does nothing to entice people into the public realm where community might develop," argues Durning.

Is sprawl good for anything? It is good for scores of industries, ranging from oil companies and car makers to lube shops and drive-through restaurants. It is good for speculators in real estate. And, because buying influence is a normal cost of business among real estate speculators, it is good for campaign contributions. Real estate interests put up 5 percent of the contributions to state legislative races in Washington from 1990 to 1994—twice as large a share as even the big-spending timber industry. They likely ac-

counted for a much larger share of contributions to candidates for city and county offices, where critical land use decisions are made. And they bankrolled most of the anti-land use planning "takings" legislation and initiatives across the Northwest during 1994 and 1995. Perhaps this influence explains why sprawl continues despite the best efforts of urban planners.<sup>3</sup>

#### ENDNOTES

1. Kunstler, James Howard. *Home from Nowhere*; pg. 39.
2. Durning, Alan Thein. *The Car and the City*; pg. 22
3. *Ibid*, pg. 29

## A CHALLENGE TO ALL

I have spent the last twenty years engaged in a protracted battle with the local development industry. I am not doing well.

Several years ago the Marysville Community Action Network (MCAN) discovered that the city's wastewater treatment plant had exceeded its capacity. The people's effluent had literally overflowed the banks of the sewage lagoon and raw waste was entering Ebey Slough, in violation of federal and state laws.

MCAN challenged the city to halt connections of new homes until it could expand its treatment facility. With considerable pressure from the State Department of Ecology, the city council agreed to impose such a moratorium, which remained in effect for a couple of years.

Before this action was taken, a representative from Ecology scheduled a community meeting in the high school auditorium. I

had mailed out several hundred postcards to residents of the greater Marysville area inviting them to attend the meeting, express their views, and show support for the moratorium proposal. I was not prepared for what happened.

The local developers and city officials had conspired to pack the auditorium with contractors, real estate agents, and other enemies of the environment, who spent the evening heckling and ridiculing MCAN members and their friends. When MCAN spoke, the development industry shouted epithets. But the builders saved their best weapon for last.

At the very end, after everyone had had their say, the then-City Attorney James Alenderfer (and now a superior court judge) approached the podium to raucous cheers from the development industry. He did not disappoint his patrons, as he defended the city's record,



denied that there was a sewer problem, and generally appeased the assembled throng of home builders and marketers. I was too stunned to be angry.

Those of you who have tried to organize for an event can appreciate the difficulties therein. People are generally loath to spend time away from their families and television sets. Volunteer organizers have the extra handicap of being unable to bribe or threaten reluctant citizens.

Not so with the developers. While I have no evidence that carpenters and electricians received overtime pay for attending that meeting, I strongly suspect that they were made aware of how their interests and those of their employers intertwined.

But that episode is behind us, and the city has renewed its rubber-stamping activities with even greater enthusiasm. Annexations continue. The hillside above the golf course and to the

north, once home to wildlife and dense forests, is now populated with large single-family houses, well-fertilized—and therefore polluting—lawns, and acres of asphalt.

Sprawl, the egregious assault on the natural and human environment, could not occur without the standing cooperation between local governments and their benefactors, as the Durning quote in the previous article reminds us. People make a lot of money scraping bare the land and erecting look-alike houses. Greed is the supreme motivator, as any good American can attest.

Well, rather than fight greed, I challenge all of us, including developers, to harness its brutal force for the commonweal. That's a tall order. City officials will have to establish a combination of financial carrots and sticks to order growth into attractive, well-built, pedestrian-friendly, environmentally benign, and compactly arranged dwelling units. In turn, such

units must be integrated carefully with parks, public facilities, retail shops, restaurants, and offices.

In short, we must start creating identifiable places. Places to recreate, congregate, integrate, communicate, and participate.

As James Howard Kunstler warns, sprawl yields nondescript mono-cultures of "nowhere." In his books *Geography to Nowhere* and *Home from Nowhere*, Kunstler decries American postwar human development of vast tracts of suburban housing connected by asphalt corridors and describing nothing.

Let me end with a quote from his first book on nowhere. I commend both books; they're stocked with irreverent quotes.

Eighty percent of everything ever built in America has been built in the last fifty years, and most of it is depressing, brutal, ugly, unhealthy, and spiritually degrading—the jive-plastic commuter tract home

wastelands, the Potemkin village shopping plazas with their vast parking lagoons, the Lego-block hotel complexes, the "gourmet mansardic" junk-food joints, the Orwellian office "parks" featuring buildings sheathed in the same reflective glass as the sunglasses worn by chain-gang guards, the particle-board garden apartments rising up in every meadow and cornfield, the freeway loops around every big and little city with their clusters of discount merchandise marts, the whole destructive, wasteful, toxic, agoraphobia-inducing spectacle that politicians proudly call "growth."

We're supposed to be bright people, Rise up. Take back the streets and make *automobiles* uncomfortable! It's the democratic thing to do.

## A TALE OF TWO STREETS

Good streets facilitate both commerce *and* community. They provide a sense of comfortable place. Above all, they are public realms. Bad streets, on the other hand, serve

only automobiles and unimaginative retailers. They are the product of misanthropic traffic engineers, narrow-minded city councils, and careless residents with no place to go.



*State Avenue (Marysville, Wash.)*



*Town Center (Redmond, Wash.)*



*Along the Ramblas*  
(Barcelona)

Drawing by Allan B. Jacobs  
Professor, Department of City and Regional Planning,  
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From: *Great Streets*, by Prof. Jacobs.

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